
Cross-X: The Art of Questioning



Questioning 101

After a speech concludes, the PO will state the speech time. In between that and when the PO dismisses the speaker, debaters can move to suspend the rules and ask questions. WACFL uses an indirect questioning format.

- Indirect Questioning
 - You ask one question and receive one answer
 - You cannot clarify your question (no back and forth) so it has to be clear!!!
 - Be straightforward and as direct/clear as possible
 - Something you can't answer with a "yes" or "no"
 - Think "why" or "how" questions
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Questioning 102:

- **Prefacing.** Do not ask questions that bring in outside information or something unmentioned in the debate (unless you ask for “Permission to Preface” before you state your question.)
 - **Two-part questions.** You cannot ask for two things, only one question.
 - **Long questions** (should be less than 7 seconds). No lengthy scenario or long-winded questions.
 - **Statements.** If they made a flawed argument, point it out with a question not a statement.
 - **Interrogatory questions.** Don’t ask “How do you respond to...”, questions should have substance.
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How to Approach Questioning Pt. 1

- Think about what you're trying to accomplish
 - Are you trying to break apart their argument?
 - Are you trying to show that your point is better?
 - Are you trying to break down the weak parts of their argument?
 - Have a clear goal in mind and know exactly what you are going to say
 - Writing down your questions can help (don't read them though, don't question with your pad)
 - Always have a backup question too
 - Don't use big fancy words, just be direct when asking or answering questions
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How to Approach Questioning Pt. 2

- In his speech Representative ___ tells us ___. In your speech you tell us _____. How does your point still stand?
 - If I can show you _____, will you switch to the aff/neg?
 - If questioning a speaker in the affirmation ask them for a real world past implementation of the program
 - If questioning a speaker in the negation ask them what they propose instead
 - Ask them about the impact of their argument: "How does this bill you're advocating for positively impact the American people."
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How to Approach Questioning Pt. 3

If you really don't know what to say in response to a question, don't say "I don't know". You have a couple of options:

- Say the question is not relevant to your speech or that it brings in untouched topics
- Dodge the question by responding with something similar to the question content
- Or if the question is ridiculous or very specific, say "I don't know Senator, but I look forward to hearing about it in your speech."

Remember to stay confident! People are more likely to believe you if you act like you know what you're saying.

Research is KEY

- Questioning is the time to prove to the judges that you know more about this topic than anyone else in the room
 - You should come in to the round knowing more facts than what you include in your speech and knowing the topic well; when you can throw in another stat in questioning it looks super nice----- keeping tabs open in round can be very helpful
 - Think beforehand about the flaws (hopefully there are none but still...) and be prepared to answer questions about that
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What to Target in Questioning

- Break apart warrant mostly
 - Target impacts
 - Use your questioning time to preempt or bring up things that your speech is about
 - But be careful because this can tip off people who have similar points - you don't want someone to stand up before you because you exposed yourself :(
 - If you have spoken already, reference your speech and make them look at their arguments in the lens of your argument
 - Break apart the logic of the argument
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Body Language in Questioning

- If you're not immediately chosen to ask a question, stand quietly as others answer questions.
 - When answering (or asking questions), stand tall and put your pad at your side/ down/ don't hold it at all
 - Hold your head up high and answer as succinctly and concisely as possible so you can get more questions asked to you
 - Think before you speak so your answers are clear
 - Don't fumble, you look weak; don't let them see you sweat
 - You probably just gave a great speech, don't let questioning be the thing that trips you up
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Some rules

- Be nice even if you are literally destroying their argument
 - Answer with a SMILE
 - Start your question with “Hi Rep _____”
 - You will be scrutinized and called aggressive by judges if you aren't perceivably nice.
 - Guys: Be aware of your privilege, you CAN do more but it's not always the best option to do more
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